TestDisk is capable of restoring lost information in a matter of minutes. It supports all major operating systems, and also RAID-configured drives. It has Linux versions as well.

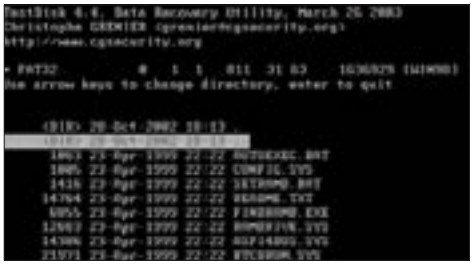
TestDisk queries the BIOS or the OS in order to find the hard disks and their characteristics. It does a quick check of the disk's structure and compares it with the Partition Table for entry errors.

If the Partition Table does have entry errors, TestDisk can repair them. If there are missing partitions or a completely empty Partition Table, TestDisk can search for partitions and create a new table or even a new Master Boot Record (MBR) if necessary. Now, a master boot record (MBR) is the first sector ("sector zero") of a partitioned hard disk, and is responsible for retaining vital system information such as the partition table, and the Bootstrap loader.

TestDisk has features for both novices and experts. For amateurs, TestDisk can be used to collect detailed information about a non-booting drive, which can then be sent to data recovery professionals for analysis. Those more familiar with such procedures should find TestDisk a handy tool in performing on-site recovery.

1. Upon starting TestDisk, you get a screen at the top that lists your available physical drives.

2. Highlight the drive you wish to recover and select the Analyze option.


TestDisk's recovery console

3. This will show the current partition structure, and upon hitting **[Enter]**, will start searching the drive to see whether the actual partitions match. Make a point to take this information down.